

DRYLANDS SUMMER SCHOOL

2nd Drylands Summer School: Monitoring Restoration in Agrosilvopastoral Systems for Sustainability and Ecosystem Services

Nairobi, Kenya – 12-15 September 2024

Summary Report

Background

The FAO Committee on Forestry Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems (COFO WG) is working to build resilient drylands by training experts to create a shared vision and to advocate for transformative dryland policymaking and management. The Drylands School program represents the forefront of this effort through the building-up of a community of knowledge and practice.

The 2nd Drylands Summer School was organized with collaboration from FAO Kenya office and in partnership with the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification's (UNCCD) G20 Global Land Initiative, the Community Jameel, the Center for International Forestry Research and World Agroforestry (CIFOR-ICRAF), the World Overview of Conservation Approaches and Technologies (WOCAT), The Swedish University of Agricultural Sciences (SLU), the Jameel Observatory, the Agricultural Research Council of South Africa (ARC-LNR), the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists (IYRP) 2026, the GEF-7 Sustainable Forest Management Impact Program on Dryland Sustainable Landscapes (DSL-IP), and the Kenya Forest Service. As well as being a partner, the UNCCD G20 Global Land Initiative was the main sponsor of the Summer School, and the Community Jameel funded the field trip.

Key elements

The overall objective of the 2nd Drylands Summer School was to strengthen capacities to follow-up, monitor, and provide feedback on the actions and related issues in sustainably managing dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral resources. It further built capacities of experts and practitioners on the transformational approach to dryland resilient systems. The specific objectives included the understanding of challenges and approaches, the review and application of monitoring frameworks, co-defining indicators and gathering data, and sharing work and building community.

The 24 participants in the Drylands School included experts, practitioners, project managers, M&E specialists, and policy makers with experience in the management of agrosilvopastoral systems within dryland areas. The program was developed along four days, including a field trip. The entire course was delivered in English. The program was professionally facilitated by CIFOR-ICRAF team, and technically supported by dryland restoration experts and specialists from FAO and the other partners. The Summer School focused on experience-sharing and networking. Participants critically reflected on their work, developed a deeper understanding of their own projects, and learned how to improve the participatory monitoring of their restoration initiatives.

Program and outcomes

The first moments of the Drylands School were devoted to understanding challenges and approaches to monitoring dryland sustainable management, degradation, and restoration processes. Opening speeches were delivered by Eliane Oulajiboro (CEO CIFOR-ICRAF), Tiina Vähänen (Deputy Director, FAO Forestry Division), Thomas Hofer (FAO Team Leader), and Cora van Oosten (CIFOR-ICRAF). The Keynote presentations were assigned to Igshaan Samuels (IYRP) and Marcelo Rezende (FAO).

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Seven dedicated technical sessions, led by different experts, addressed critical issues on monitoring and transforming Drylands, including monitoring frameworks, specific tools and approaches, practices, design and implementation of indicators, adapting monitoring to pastoralist communities, etc.

Along the entire Drylands Summer School participants worked on their case studies both at individual and small group level, focusing on the development of sound monitoring frameworks for their restoration and management projects. Activities related to the case studies included participatory landscape mapping, group discussions, practical approaches to monitoring tools, etc.

The program was complemented by a field trip on the 3rd day. The participants visited the KEFRI TIVA Woodland Conservation site in Kwa Vonzia including a nursery and a plantation of *Melia volkensii*. The field trip also visited the KEFRI Drylands Eco-Region Research Programme (DERP) in Kitui town and a local commercial forest farmer belonging to the Kyawea Community Forest Association.

The closure of the Summer School was led by Igshaan Samuels (IYRP) and Thomas Hofer (FAO) sharing with participants their ideas to continue strengthening the Drylands School and discussing to some of the incoming challenges and opportunities. With the upcoming International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists 2026 and the International Rangeland Congress next year in Adelaide, the third Drylands School presents many possibilities for growth and collaboration. Deliberations were also held on how to ensure that the group stays connected in the building up of a growing network of dryland restoration professionals across the world. Finally, Tiina Vähänen closed the school and gave the farewell.

Conclusion

The Drylands Summer School experience has raised a great interest and positive critics among the Drylands Community due to its global focus, the long-lasting aim of developing a real community of knowledge and practice around Drylands and the engagement of the international partnership behind its development. The next edition will be celebrated in Adelaide, Australia during the last week of May 2025, ahead of the 2025 International Rangeland Congress. The 4th Drylands School will be held in Mongolia, in 2026 framed by the celebration of the International Year of Rangelands and Pastoralists.

